

Attending college through the Advancing Students Toward Education and Employment (ASTEP) Program at Minot State University (MSU) and its satellite campus (Dakota College at Bottineau) provided many opportunities for Holly Scheetz and Joe McNeil, both of whom have intellectual disability. One moment of inclusion was especially meaningful: attending the regular college commencement ceremony. ASTEP has been supporting students with intellectual disability to attend MSU since 2011, and spring 2017 was the first time ASTEP students were included in the ceremony.

Joe and Holly had been involved in many aspects of campus life throughout their time at MSU. Both students were enrolled in inclusive coursework that was aligned with their career goals. Small class sizes enabled Holly and Joe to consistently interact with their professors and classmates on a personal level.

Holly and Joe participated in a variety of employment opportunities, working at Enrollment Services, the Registrar's Office, and the Athletic Department. In

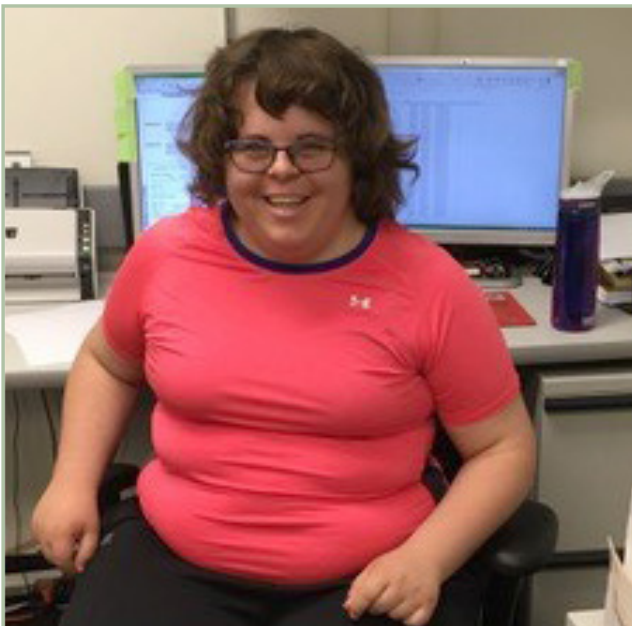


Holly and Joe on Commencement Day at MSU.

addition to gaining valuable academic and employment skills, they also lived on campus in residence halls with other MSU students. They both were involved in campus life activities that helped them gain skills related to communication, recreation, and socializing with their peers.

Both Joe and Holly enjoyed attending concerts, theater performances, movies, and sporting events during their time at college. Holly supported the Minot State Women's basketball team as a student manager. Joe was also a loyal Beaver fan, and attended all of the MSU athletic events during his three years on campus. Holly and Joe developed friendships and social networks, and were well known on campus by fellow students, faculty, and staff.

Although ASTEP students are fully included in college, the opportunity for them to participate in the MSU commencement ceremony was not a reality until spring



Holly at work in the MSU Registrar's Office while enrolled in ASTEP.

"I don't know what I would do without graduating from Minot with a diploma and lots of advice from professors and family members. The tassel was worth the hassle."

—Holly

ASTEP's staffers are excited for future graduates to participate in campus life, and in the traditional MSU commencement ceremony, for years to come. Commencement is a moment for all students to celebrate their accomplishments with their peers, and to look forward to their future.

2017. The idea began as a discussion point during a winter ASTEP advisory committee meeting. Members of the advisory committee also served on the campus commencement committee. Since these committee members personally knew Joe and Holly, they had genuine interest in making an inclusive commencement ceremony happen.

The advisory committee members understood the positive impact that taking part in commencement would have on Holly, Joe, and their families. However, this was something new, and needed to be proposed to the university's administration. Through the advocacy of the advisory committee members and the support of other campus partners, discussions, advocacy, and collaboration took place to make this idea a reality.



Joe after he threw out the ceremonial first pitch at the MSU women's softball game. Joe was honored for being such a loyal MSU athletics fan.

On May 12, 2017, Holly and Joe, wearing their caps and gowns, participated in the commencement ceremony with their peers whom they had lived in the residence halls, taken classes, studied, and become friends. It seemed like the logical thing: Why exclude them from the commencement ceremony when they are included in all other aspects of campus life?

Holly shared her observation of being included, saying, "I don't know what I would do without graduating from Minot with a diploma and lots of advice from professors and family members. The tassel was worth the hassle."

ASTEP staff members recognize that students attending other postsecondary education programs have participated in inclusive commencements. However, this is a significant accomplishment for MSU because of the precedent it sets.

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Author Information

AMY ARMSTRONG is the project director for ASTEP, which is coordinated by the North Dakota Center for Persons with Disabilities (NDCPD) at Minot State University (MSU). NDCPD is a University Center for Excellence on Development Disabilities (UCEDD). Since joining NDCPD in 2001, Amy has worked on a variety of projects. Currently her work focuses on working youth and young adults with disabilities and their transition to post-secondary education and integrated community employment. Amy met Holly and Joe almost five years ago, while they were in high school exploring the possibility of attending college through ASTEP.

JOLYNN WEBSTER is a Program Coordinator for ASTEP which includes student advising as well as coordination of employment internships on and off campus. As a member of the MSU department of Special Education, JoLynn also oversees practicum experiences for ASTEP. JoLynn was Joe's Program Advisor throughout his three years enrolled in ASTEP and worked closely with both Joe and Holly in their employment internships.